Evripidis Vakalis

Backend Tech Lead, API Integrations

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Summary

Backend engineer and tech lead working mainly with PHP (Symfony) and third-party API integrations. Leads the team that connects property management systems and channel managers to a travel distribution platform. Focused on maintainable architecture, code quality and the practical use of AI in software development, with an MSc thesis in machine learning and NLP for legal text classification. Earlier experience in Python (Django), e-commerce and data analysis.

Technologies

Languages: PHP 8, Python, SQL, JavaScript

Frameworks: Symfony, Django, WordPress, WooCommerce

Data: MySQL, MariaDB, MongoDB, Memcached, Elasticsearch

Infrastructure: Docker, Kubernetes (GKE), GitHub Actions, Jenkins, Gearman, New Relic

Code Quality: PHPUnit, PHPStan, Rector, PHP-CS-Fixer

AI Tooling: Claude Code, Claude Agent SDK, MCP, AI agents

Machine Learning & NLP: scikit-learn, XGBoost, PyTorch, Hugging Face Transformers, Optuna, NLTK

Integration: REST, SOAP, webhooks, OAuth 2.0, microservices

Experience

Tech Lead, Backend & Integrations (Remote) @ TravelStaytion — 2023 - Present

Leadership

- Lead the supply integrations team and join engineering leadership and management meetings.
- Guide technical decisions, write product requirements and mentor engineers through design and code reviews.
- Wrote postmortems, integration docs and runbooks.

Architecture & Integrations

- Designed a shared sync framework so common logic is written once for all integrations.
- Built and led new PMS and channel manager integrations, adding new property sources.

Code Quality & Upgrades

- Introduced static analysis, automated refactoring and unit testing (PHPStan, Rector, PHP-CS-Fixer, PHPUnit).
- Led our PHP upgrades with a reusable regression test harness, and planned the upgrade path for the company's other services.

AI-Assisted Development

- Lead Claude Code adoption in engineering: shared configuration, review agents and workflows connected to monitoring, logs and vendor docs.
- Automated support and operations work with AI: reservation investigations, ticket triage, partner onboarding, deploy checks, and daily reviews of production errors and vendor API changes.
- Contribute to an internal AI agent that traces support issues through tickets, code and logs to resolve them at first contact.

Tech: PHP, Symfony, MySQL, MariaDB, MongoDB, Gearman, Memcached, Docker, GKE, GitHub Actions, Jenkins, New Relic, Elasticsearch, PHPUnit, PHPStan, Rector, Claude Code, Claude Agent SDK

Web Developer, eCommerce Website Administrator @ Soundstar 2016 - 2022

eCommerce & Digital Growth

- Designed and launched the company's WordPress/WooCommerce platform, integrating inventory and payments.
- Led digital transformation, tripling organic traffic and increasing sales.

Automation & Data Systems

- Built a Django-based scraping and reporting tool for pricing insights.
- Developed internal analytics and marketing automation using Python and KNIME.

Team & Operations

- Coordinated content, marketing, and technical teams.
- Mentored junior engineers and managed vendors and hosting providers.

Tech: WordPress, WooCommerce, Python, Django, HTML, CSS, PHP, JavaScript, KNIME, Web Scraping, Data Analysis

Web Developer, PC Service & IT @ Adminia 2013 - 2015

- Developed and maintained CMS sites (OpenCart, WordPress, Joomla, Drupal).
- Provided workstation support, hardware repair and remote assistance for customers.

Tech: OpenCart, WordPress, HTML, CSS, PHP, JavaScript

Internship, Department of Electronics @ Hellenic Aerospace Industry 2010

- Programmed and operated SMD assembly machinery.
- Took part in wireless network design and installation.

Education

MSc, Postgraduate specialization in information systems 2020 - 2025

Hellenic Open University

Part-time, alongside full-time work

Thesis: Automatic legal text classification on European Convention on Human Rights (ECHR) cases

Compared classical ML (linear SVM, XGBoost, neural networks) with transformers (DistilBERT, Longformer).

BSc, Automation Technician 2014

Technological Educational Institute of Chalkida

Artificial Intelligence 2007 - 2008

University of Southern Denmark (Syddansk Universitet), Odense

Erasmus Programme

Additional Certificates

National and Kapodistrian University of Athens

Centre of Continuous Education and Training

Data Analyst (2018), Website and Marketing Operations for Small Tourist Units (2018), Digital Marketing (2017), Marketing and Branding Mix (2017)

Languages

Greek: Native

English: Fluent (Cambridge First Certificate in English)